



Entertainment

High-fidelity and high-definition here

Samsung Bordeaux LA32R81B

Chances are you're going to get a pretty good offer on this TV these holidays. The 32R8 is a black beauty from the Samsung Bordeaux collection, and is one revision up from its predecessor the LA32R71B. The newer model is slightly sleeker looking (not that any improvement was required to begin with), and the contrast ratio has been beefed up from 5000:1 to 8000:1 on the new range. Prices have fallen as well, and the TV was retailing for Rs 52,000 the last time we checked, and may even fall further during the shopping season.

The display is not true HD, and is 1080i (1366 x 768), which shouldn't be much of a problem for most, because we hardly have any 1080i capable outputs. If you own a PS3 or Xbox though, you might want to look at full HD displays.

The brightness is rated at 550 cd/m2, and coupled with a viewing angle of 178 degrees, this makes the TV well viewable from everywhere in your room. The inbuilt speakers aren't great, and at 10 watt RMS don't pack a punch—but you can't have everything now can you?

There are 3 HDMI inputs, so those of you who want to be able to simultaneously connect multiple HD sources are in luck here. There's PC connectivity as well, via a D-sub port that connects directly to your graphics card. We love the picture-in-picture implementation on this TV though, which comes in handy when you've connected your PC up and want to watch the cricket match while you work. Picture quality is good and this is a good buy for most people.

Also available in the Indian market are the older R7 models of



this 32-inch TV, and you should check carefully what you're buying. There's nothing wrong with the R7 series per se, and if you get a good deal on one, they're still great buys. The difference is that the R7s feature just a single HDMI port and a reduced contrast ratio of 5000:1. A good idea would be to look for clearance sales of the R7, and if you get lucky, you could get them for Rs 42,000 or less—a good buy if you're not interested in hooking up too many HD sources (of which we have so few anyway in India). Those of you with friends / relatives going to the gulf might want to ask them to check for the R7s there—one of our colleagues got an LA32R71B for a mere 27,000 at a clearance sale in the gulf!

Now there are those of you who will want larger than 32 inch TVs, or just insist on full HD (1080p) TVs. Be prepared to pay a steep price though. If you've got a budget of over 1,50,000, you may want to take a look at full HD LCDs and Plasmas from Philips, Sony and Hitachi. The Philips Ambilight LCE TVs are also something you may want to look at—they're different and definitely a good looking addition to any wall. Speaking of good looking, the Sony Bravia line has some really nice full HD TVs, and they've got some good discounts and offers lined up this Diwali.

Bose QuietComfort 3

With all that shopping you're planning, chances are you're going to have a lot of new audio-visual gear at home—all of which is useless at 2:00 AM when you want to catch that flick on TV or when you just want to chill to some loud music. If your family doesn't kill you first, your neighbours will. The only option is to take your entertainment to more personal level, and get headphones. However, not just any headphones, because what use is it watching your favourite movie or listening to that Beethoven/Van Halen/Madonna/Linkin' Park/(we could go on forever) CD on a substandard pair of headphones.

Audio quality is something you can stop worrying about as soon as the word Bose is mentioned. We all know they're good, period. Bose's QuietComfort 3 Acoustic Noise Cancelling Headphones are something everyone should have, but not just anyone can afford. Priced at Rs 21,263, these headphones cause most of us to sputter in awe when we hear the price tag. "Why?" is generally the next question we all ask; here's the answer:

The headphones are *really* noise cancelling, and putting them on isolate you from the noise around, as well as ensure that any

noise in your music is electronically cut out. They also feature active equalisation—electronics in the headset analyse and control the frequency response of the headphones, on-the-fly, to ensure the best audio quality always. In short, you have to hear them to believe them. Only for those with money to splurge though, or those who have ears as sensitive as professional composers. They do make for some serious flaunt value though!



Time To Open The Goodies

We certainly hope that this article has inspired you to go out and look for good deals... Remember, there are plenty more great ones out there in every segment we've mentioned; these are just suggestions.

If you *do* buy any of the products we've mentioned, write in and let us know about your experience. We'd also love to hear what you *did* buy this Diwali, even if it's not on our list! ■

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